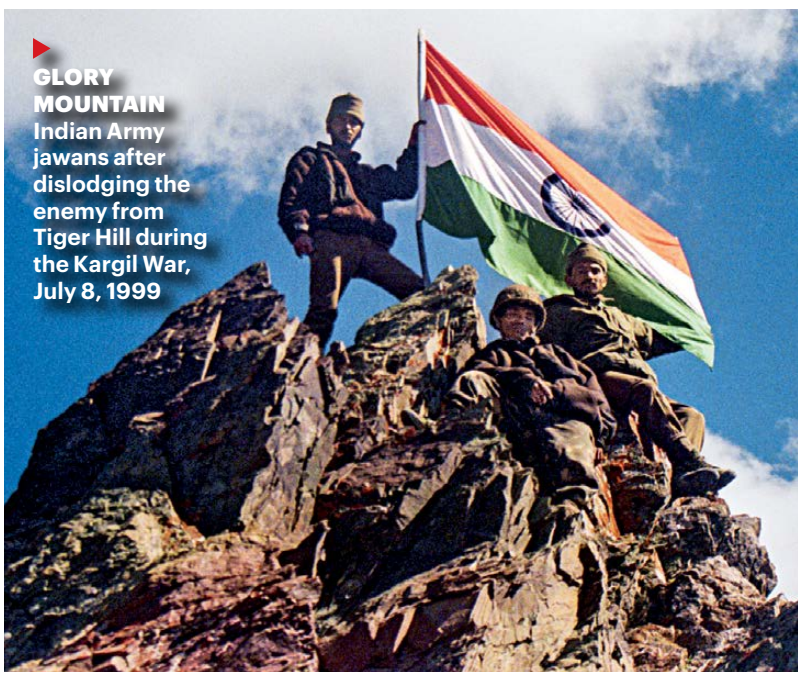
The stark setting tells half the story: the icy wastes of the Siachen Glacier in northern Ladakh and the commanding heights and mountain passes around it, with an average altitude of 20,000 feet. Starting from April 13, 1984, the Indian Army, ably ferried and supplied by the Indian Air Force, secured the glacier, of immense strategic importance, for the nation under Operation Meghdoot. It is a high point in Indian military history, for seldom has the fortitude of our fighting men been tested in such punishing terrain and climate. Siachen remains the world's highest battlefield.

The genesis of Op. Meghdoot lay in the ambiguous demarcation of the Line of Control (LoC) between India and Pakistan, with the LoC ending at Point NJ9842 and the area "proceeding north to the glaciers" left unclear. Pakistan began permitting foreign expeditions to the glacier in the 1970s, bolstering its claims to the territory. When intelligence reports revealed that Pakistan was preparing to occupy it, India struck preemptively. Men and officers of the Kumaon Regiment and the Ladakh Scouts faced blizzards, braved avalanches and endured subarctic temperatures—scores lost their lives to hypothermia. Soon, key positions such as the Bilafond La, Sia La and other vital passes were occupied. Securing Siachen ensured that India controlled the area adjoining the Saltoro Ridge. It served as a buffer against collaboration between Pakistan and China in the region.

Op. Meghdoot—and the continuing presence in Siachen—prepared the Indian military in ways that were appreciated in 1999, when Pakistani forces and militants infiltrated Indian territory in the Kargil sector of Jammu and Kashmir, occupied high-altitude positions, including Tiger Hill and Tololing, and threatened National Highway 1A—a critical supply route to Leh. India responded with Operation Vijay, and after intense fighting, its forces recaptured most of the occupied territories by mid-July. The IAF's fighter jets pulverised enemy positions with precision strikes. India lost 527 soldiers; Pakistani losses were over 700. The daring of Op. Meghdoot emphasised the need for readiness in safeguarding national interests. After Kargil, that was demonstrated on the night of September 28-29, 2016, when India conducted surgical strikes across the LoC in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir following the Uri terror attack. It was carried out by 70 special forces commandos, who killed 30-40 terrorists in seven terrorist launch pads. The spirit of Meghdoot also hovers over the Balakot air strike on February 26, 2019, which was India's response to the Pulwama terror attack. IAF jets crossed the LoC and struck and destroyed a Jaish-e-Mohammed terrorist training camp in Balakot, deep within Pakistan's territory. ■



GLORY MOUNTAIN Indian Army jawans after dislodging the enemy from Tiger Hill during the Kargil War, July 8, 1999

FROM THE ARCHIVES
Sep. 30, 1984

Defence
Mountain Marauders



Mountain Marauders

Elements of the Kumaon Regiment were flown to Thoise, an airfield close to the Chinese border. The troops undertook a perilous trek to the glacier, losing an officer and 19 ranks to an avalanche. But they overwhelmed the Pakistanis manning the post after a fierce fight. The Pakistanis have been counter-attacking but in spite of frost-bite, exposure and pulmonary oedema, the Kumaonis are holding out.
-Shekhar Gupta

DID YOU KNOW?

Maintaining troops at Siachen costs India approximately Rs 5–7 crore daily, making it one of the most expensive military deployments globally